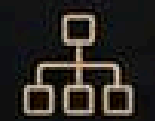


Designing for a Dense Strategy System

My Role:

 Complex workflows

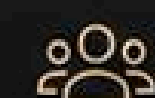
 Information architecture

 Interaction patterns

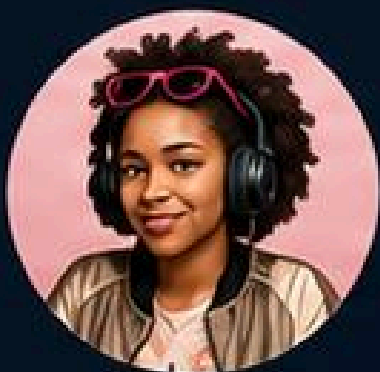
 Accessibility

 Scalable design systems

 Interactive prototypes

 User testing

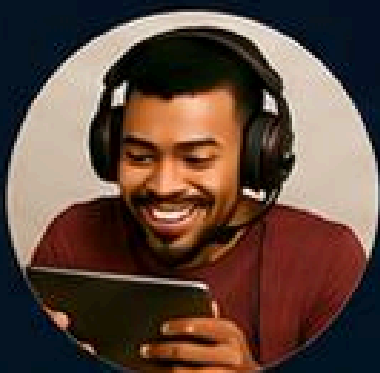




Kristin
Story-driven player

- Immersion
- Story
- Fantasy
- Guidance

- Comes for the world, characters, and dragons.
- Needs clearer guidance and lower cognitive load.



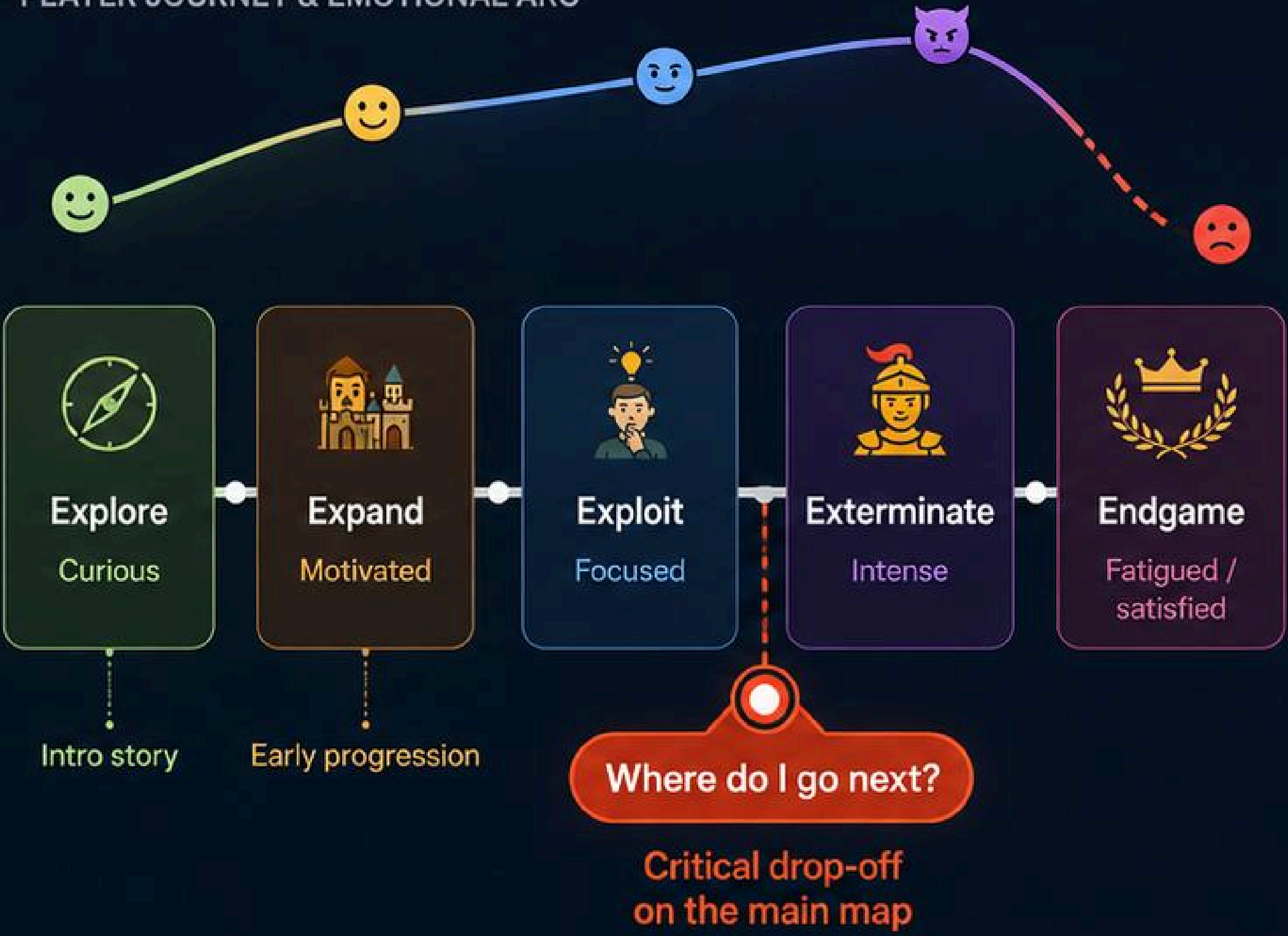
Marcus
Strategy expert

- Planning
- Control
- Depth
- Optimization

- Comes for mechanics, systems, and smart decision-making.
- Needs visibility into mechanics and meaningful choices.

Design challenge: make the experience intuitive for Kristin without oversimplifying it for Marcus.

PLAYER JOURNEY & EMOTIONAL ARC



WHAT PLAYTESTING REVEALED

- Overwhelming interface**
Too many elements compete for attention.
- Inconsistent visual hierarchy**
Important information is hard to parse.
- Unclear action priority**
Players aren't sure what to do next.

Both player types entered with excitement, but lost confidence when the core gameplay became unclear.



Guide first actions
Make the next step visible.



Reduce cognitive load
Simplify dense screens.



Clarify system feedback
Show status, cause, and consequence.



Reveal complexity progressively
Support novices and experts.



Player interviews & playtests



Strong initial excitement



Friction begins at the main map



Unclear next steps reduce confidence



Audience framing

Story-first



Immersion
Guidance

Lower cognitive load



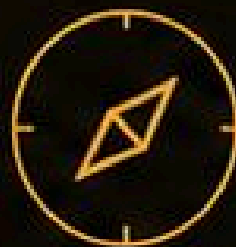
Strategy-first



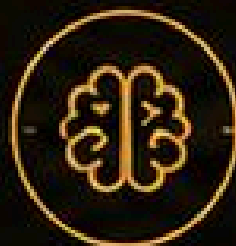
Depth
Control

Meaningful decisions

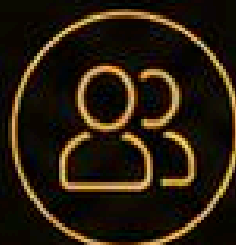
Research takeaways



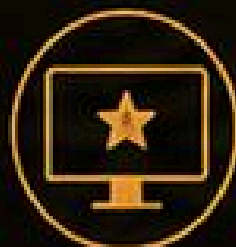
Clarify next steps



Reduce cognitive load



Support multiple
expertise levels



Align visual richness
with usability



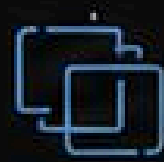
Competitive analysis



Navigation &
wayfinding



Information
hierarchy



Progressive
disclosure



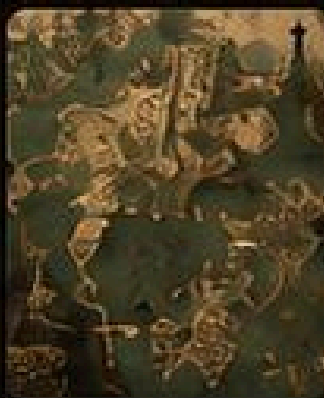
System feedback
& status clarity



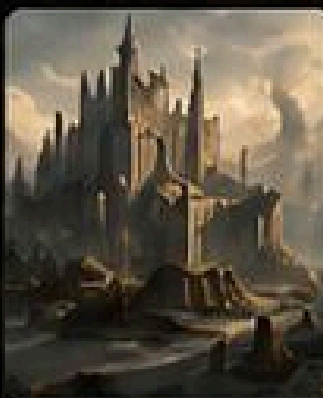
Onboarding &
first-use
guidance



Visual-system exploration with art team



Map style &
readability



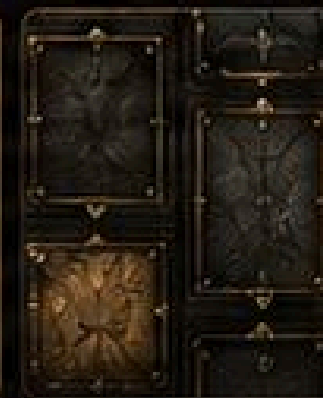
Architecture &
world scale



Heraldry &
symbols



Dragon taxonomy
& creatures



UI textures &
panels

UX Audit Observations | Overwhelming Data & Unclear Next Steps



A World map decomposition

- A Node Details
- B Node Details Ext.
- C Node Controls
- D Node Type/Level
- E Node Actions
- F Occupation Info



B Node details (core panel)



C Node details (extended panel)



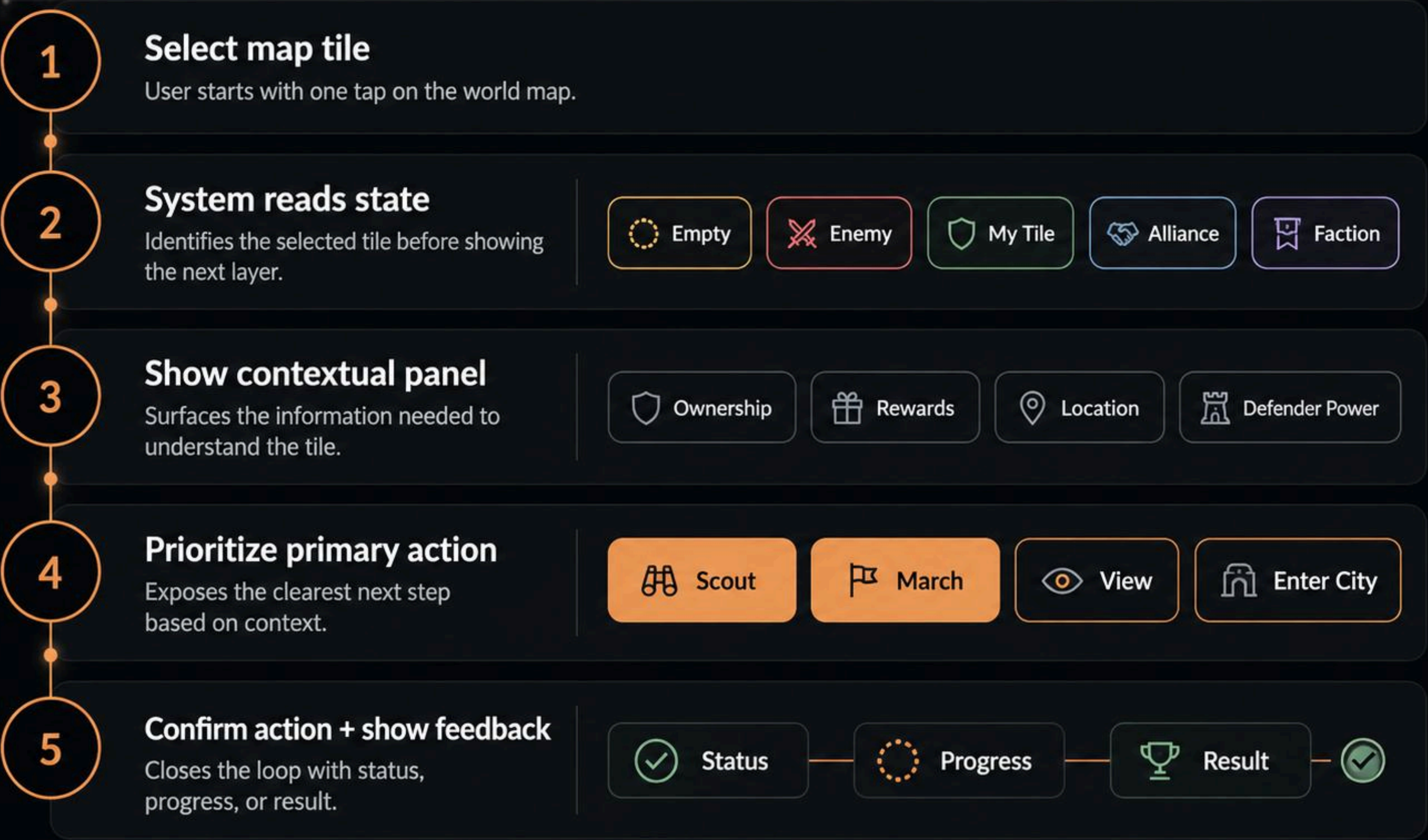
KEY LEARNINGS → DESIGN DECISIONS

Navigation
Too many entry points weaken orientation → Simplify routes from map to action.

Hierarchy
Important information competes at the same level → Prioritize primary state and actions.

Map state
Ownership and tile meaning need faster recognition → Standardize selected, owned, and contested states.

Action visibility
Users need clear, reachable actions → Pair icons with labels and predictable placement.



Design rule

One interaction pattern, multiple states. The system changes content and primary action based on tile context.



Defender Panel

1,800

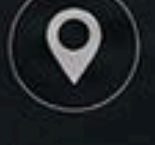
REWARDS

Wood

+50/h

Food

+50/h

[Region Name]

999,999

SCOUT



TILE INFO PANEL TEMPLATES (REUSABLE FOR ALL STATES)



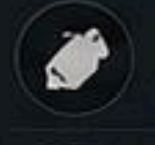
EMPTY

Unclaimed
(Empty)

DEFENDER POWER

1,800

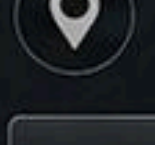
REWARDS

Wood

+50/h

Food

+50/h

[Region Name]

999,999

SCOUT



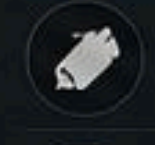
ENEMY

Enemy

DEFENDER POWER

1,800

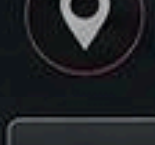
REWARDS

Wood

+50/h

Food

+50/h

[Region Name]

999,999

SCOUT



MY TILE

You

DEFENDER POWER

1,800

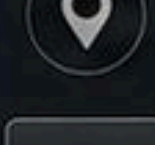
REWARDS

Wood

+50/h

Food

+50/h

[Region Name]

999,999

SCOUT



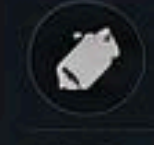
ALLIANCE

Alliance Member

DEFENDER POWER

1,800

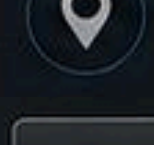
REWARDS

Wood

+50/h

Food

+50/h

[Region Name]

999,999

SCOUT



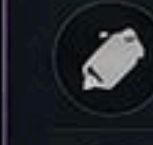
FACTION

Faction Member

DEFENDER POWER

1,800

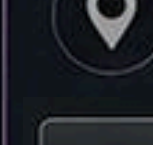
REWARDS

Wood

+50/h

Food

+50/h

[Region Name]

999,999

SCOUT

ENTER MY CITY BEHAVIOR

A1 Info Panel Behavior

The standard left-side info panel still appears when any tile is selected, including your own.

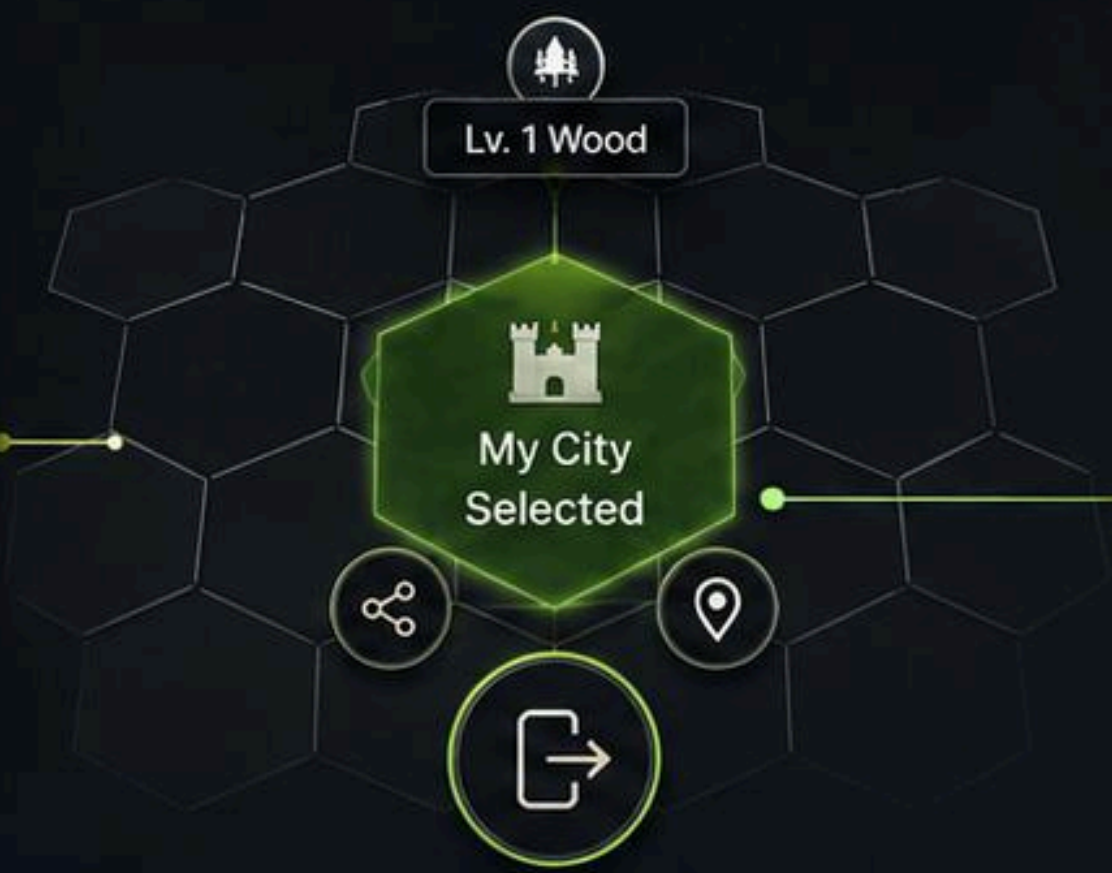
Defender Power
1,800

Rewards

Wood
x1

Food
560/h

[Region Name]
999,999



A2 Primary Action Changes

For your own city, the primary context action becomes **Enter City** instead of the usual node action.



My Castle Interaction

- Player-owned territory UI.
- Direct entry into the city from the selected tile.
- Clear primary action for faster navigation.
- Simplified layout for comfort and readability.
- Reinforces player ownership and identity.



Margin
45 px

Safe zone
Keep controls
away from edges
and overlaps

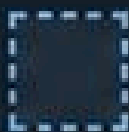
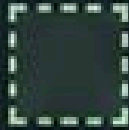
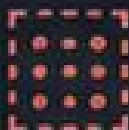
Bottom tap menu
Contains primary
navigation and
must stay within
defined density



16 px

Safe area
Height
390 px

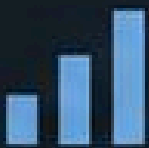
13 px

-  Minimum target
45 × 45 px
-  Optimal target
48 × 48 px
-  Thumb reference
71 × 71 px
-  Recommended
interaction range
45–57 px
-  Safe zones keep controls
away from edge conflict
-  Bottom tap menu and
top bar actions must
stay within defined density

Implementation guardrails



Use defined placeholders
for every interactive control
Plan first, build consistent
experiences.



Do not exceed
recommended HUD density
Respect slot counts and spacing
limits to avoid clutter.



Keep primary actions
inside thumb-reachable zones
Prioritize reach and visibility
for critical actions.



Preserve consistent spacing,
margins, and touch sizes
across teams
Follow the same rules everywhere
for reliable implementation.



Prevents clutter, accidental
taps, and inconsistent
implementation.

A



B



C





INFO PANEL VARIANTS

DEFENDER
Defender Power

Defender Power
1800

Rewards

Wood
+50/h

Food
+50/h

[Region Name]
999,999

SCOUT

[PLAYER NAME]
ALLIANCE NAME

Defender Power
1800

Rewards

Wood
+50/h

Food
+50/h

[Region Name]
999,999

VIEW

ALLY
ALLIANCE NAME

Defender Power
1800

Rewards

Wood
+50/h

Food
+50/h

[Region Name]
999,999

VIEW

FRIENDLY
ALLIANCE NAME

Defender Power
1800

Rewards

Wood
+50/h

Food
+50/h

[Region Name]
999,999

VIEW

NEUTRAL
REGION

Defender Power
1800

Rewards

Wood
+50/h

Food
+50/h

[Region Name]
999,999

SCOUT

ENEMY
HOSTILE

Defender Power
1800

Rewards

Wood
+50/h

Food
+50/h

[Region Name]
999,999

SCOUT

COMPACT INFO PANELS

DEFENDER
1800

ALLY
ALLIANCE
1800

ENEMY
HOSTILE
1800

NEUTRAL
1800

FRIENDLY
ALLIANCE
1800

REGION
999,999

3. NAVIGATION & ACTION SYSTEM

PRIMARY

City

Fortress

Dragon

Attack

Scout

Eye

Stats

World

Ship

Map

Share

Pin

Resource

SaveId

Alliance

Rally

Chat

Mail

Market

Bag

Quest

Settings

Help

More

1. MAP & TILE SYSTEM

WORLD MAP EXAMPLE

Your Territory
Northreach
1,250 / 1,500

ENTER CITY

TILE STATES

Friendly

Ally

Selected

Enemy

Neutral

TILE STATUS EXAMPLES

Resource

Stronghold

Objective

Ruins

Blocked

TABS / SEGMENTED CONTROL

Overview

Armies

Buildings

Activity

4. FOUNDATIONS & SYSTEM CUES

GRAYSCALE-FIRST APPROACH

01
Structure
Layout &
Information
Architecture

02
Grayscale
Clarity &
Hierarchy
Testing

03
Accessibility
Contrast &
Readability
Validation

04
Accents
Meaning &
Interaction
Feedback

TYPOGRAPHY

Aa Cinzel
Primary Typeface

Aa Inter
UI / Body

123,456
Numerals

2. UI COMPONENTS

RESOURCE TOP BAR

72.4K

128.4K

96.1K

64.2K

12.4K

2,450

+

PLAYER / TERRITORY CARD

Northreach

You

Defender Power
1,850

1,250 / 1,500

Region
Stormspire

Population
36 / 66

MARCH CTA

MARCH

DEFENDER REWARDS

Defender Power
1,850

Rewards

Wood +50 / h

Food +50 / h

Iron +50 / h

Gold +50 / h

SCOUT

LOCATION / REGION CARD

Stormspire

Neutral

Highlands

Owner
You

Control
Contested

PROGRESS & STATS

Progress Bar

1,250 / 1,500

Stat (Abbreviated)
1.25K

Stat (Compact)
36/66

Percent
75%

MARCH / ARMY PANEL

Marching

Main Army
4,000

Load
30 / 80

(192, 129) → (194, 1945)

RECALL ARMY

SCOUT / TARGET PREVIEW

Enemy Stronghold
Krag'Torak

Defender Power
2,100

Rewards

Wood +50 / h

Food +50 / h

Iron +50 / h

Gold +50 / h

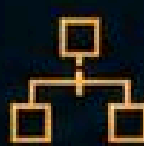
SCOUT



My Role



Translated playtest friction into interaction requirements



Defined reusable rules for states, actions, panels, and navigation



Balanced visual richness with usability, hierarchy, and clarity



Design rule:
One interaction model, multiple states.
Context changes content, action, and feedback.



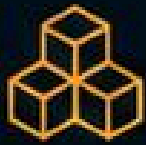
Value Delivered



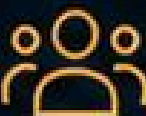
Clearer path from orientation to action



More predictable state, feedback, and primary actions



Reusable interaction patterns that scale



Stronger alignment across product, design, art, and engineering

1



Select

Tile / City / Object

2



Interpret State

Empty / Enemy / Owned

3



Prioritize Action

Scout / March / View

4



Give Feedback

Selected / Blocked / In Progress

5



Continue

Return to Map / Next Decision